Private Pilot Study Library

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The private pilot airplane knowledge test (code PAR) is 60 multiple-choice questions in 120 minutes with a 70% pass mark, and everything it tests comes from free FAA documents. The FAA no longer releases its live question bank, so the only official practice questions are one 61-question sample exam and the PSI practice tests; every commercial bank is a reconstruction. Study the FAA sources first, drill with a practice bank second.

What changed recently

Anything printed before late 2025 is missing at least one of these updates, so check the edition on any used book or old PDF.

Date	Item	What it means for you
2026, ongoing	Test images move on screen	Private pilot questions already show charts and figures on screen; the printed supplement is still handed out, with no removal date set. FAA advisory, Sept 2026
Sept 2026	PSI moving to its Test Taker Portal	Booking and score reports go paperless; test content is unchanged.
July 9, 2026	AIM Change 3	Current AIM is the Feb 20, 2025 basic with Changes 1 to 3. FAA publications
Apr 2, 2026	Aviation Weather Handbook revised	New edition (sold as FAA-H-8083-28B) replaces the Dec 2024 28A.
Nov 14, 2025	AC 61-65K	New endorsement wording your instructor uses; replaces 61-65J.
Oct 2025	MOSAIC addenda	Separate addendum PDFs for the PHAK, Airplane Flying Handbook and Weight & Balance Handbook; read them alongside the main books.
May 31, 2024	ACS FAA-S-ACS-6C	Still the current checkride standard as of Sept 16, 2026.

Official FAA study documents

These nine free documents are the source for every test question and every checkride task. All are U.S. government publications and free to download.

Document	Current edition	Use it for
Private Pilot for Airplane Category ACS	FAA-S-ACS-6C, effective May 31, 2024	The syllabus. Lists every knowledge, risk and skill item you can be tested on.
ACS Companion Guide for Pilots	FAA-G-ACS-2, with Changes 1 and 2	How the checkride is run, what to bring, how tolerances are judged.
Pilot's Handbook of Aeronautical Knowledge	FAA-H-8083-25C (2023) plus Oct 2025 addendum	Main textbook for the written: aerodynamics, systems, weather, navigation, human factors.
Airplane Flying Handbook	FAA-H-8083-3C (2021) plus Oct 2025 addendum	How each maneuver is flown; the reference for the flight portion.
Aviation Weather Handbook	FAA-H-8083-28, revised Apr 2, 2026	Weather theory and products. Replaced the old AC 00-6 and AC 00-45.
Aeronautical Information Manual	Basic with Changes 1 to 3, effective July 9, 2026	Airspace, ATC procedures, radio phraseology, airport markings. Includes the Pilot/Controller Glossary.
Testing Supplement FAA-CT-8080-2H	2018	The exact figures, charts and performance tables used on the written. Practice every question with it open.
Risk Management Handbook	FAA-H-8083-2A (2022)	The "R" items in the ACS: PAVE, IMSAFE, decision-making.
Weight & Balance Handbook	FAA-H-8083-1B (2016) plus Oct 2025 addendum	Loading and center-of-gravity problems.

Smaller FAA references worth having: the Aeronautical Chart Users' Guide for every sectional symbol, the aeromedical safety brochures, and Plane Sense for aircraft documents and maintenance rules. The full list is on the FAA handbooks page.

Official practice questions

The FAA publishes one sample exam for PAR and keeps the live bank confidential, so treat these as format practice, not a preview of your test.

Resource	What you get
FAA PAR sample questions (PDF)	61 questions dated Aug 10, 2021, each tagged with its ACS code. No answer key is printed.
PSI practice tests	The FAA's testing vendor hosts the official sample tests, scored, in the real test interface. Free with an account. Also where the PAR Candidate Information Bulletin lives.
Learning Statement Reference Guide	Decodes the codes on a score report.
Knowledge test statistics	Pass rates by test, plus the quarterly Frequently Missed ACS Codes report.
Knowledge Testing Matrix	Eligibility, ID and authorization rules for every test code.
Airman Testing FAQ	Registration, retakes, lost score reports.
Airman Testing Community Advisory	Posted every month or two; the only place the FAA announces test changes.

The frequently-missed report tells you where to spend extra time. For July 2024 through June 2025 the one PAR code missed more than 70% of the time was PA.IX.A.K3 (Emergency Operations), at 73.33%. Earlier reports flagged PA.VI.A.K1 (Navigation) at 86.83% and PA.VIII.C.K1c (Basic Instrument Maneuvers) at 77.24%. Look each code up in the ACS to see the exact item.

Third-party practice tests and ground schools

Sporty's free practice tests are the best no-cost question bank; pay for a course only if you want video lessons or need the written-test endorsement without going through your instructor.

Provider	Cost	What it is
Sporty's free FAA practice tests	Free	Unlimited timed 60-question private pilot practice tests, online.
King Schools course demo	Free	Sample lessons plus the question review for those lessons.
Gleim demos	Free	Study Unit 1 of the ground school and a trial of Test Prep Online.
Sporty's Learn to Fly Course	Paid	Video ground school plus test prep; 2026 edition covers both private and sport tracks.
King Schools Private Pilot Ground School & Test Prep	Paid	About 15 hours of video, unlimited random practice tests, pass guarantee.
Gleim Online Ground School and Test Prep	Paid	Text-based, outline style; gives the written-test sign-off on completion.
ASA Private Pilot Test Prep with Prepware	$29.95 at Sporty's	Book plus software plus 24 months of Prepware Online; includes the test endorsement.
Pilot Institute	Paid	Video ground school; their free written-test checklist is a good walkthrough of the PSI signup.

Sheppard Air, the memorization bank people recommend for instrument and ATP, does not sell a private pilot course according to pilot-forum reports, so skip any advice pointing you there. Other names you will hear and that I did not re-check today: Rod Machado, Gold Seal, MzeroA, FLY8MA, Angle of Attack, and Dauntless GroundSchool for paid courses; Boldmethod quizzes and CFI Notebook for free reading. Be wary of new app-store question banks with a few hundred "FAA-style" questions and a subscription; none of them has anything the sources above lack.

Prices move with sales, so check the provider's page before buying. Courses differ mainly in teaching style, since they all teach from the same FAA documents.

Checkride and oral exam prep

The examiner can only test what is in the ACS, so the ACS is your oral exam study guide; work through it task by task and be able to explain every K and R item out loud.

Resource	Use it for
ACS FAA-S-ACS-6C	Twelve Areas of Operation, from Preflight Preparation to Postflight Procedures, with the pass tolerances for each maneuver.
ACS Companion Guide	Checkride-day checklist, what counts as unsatisfactory, how a discontinuance works.
Your knowledge test report	Lists the ACS codes you missed. Your instructor must endorse that you reviewed them (14 CFR 61.39), and examiners probe those areas in the oral.
ASA Private Pilot Oral Exam Guide	15th edition, April 2026, $14.95 at Sporty's. Question-and-answer format with FAA references.
Your aircraft's POH/AFM	Systems, limitations, V-speeds, performance charts and weight and balance for the actual airplane you will fly.
AC 61-65K (Nov 14, 2025)	The endorsement wording your logbook needs. Find it through the FAA advisory circulars page.
FAA designee locator	Finds Designated Pilot Examiners near you.
ACS FAQ	Short answers on how the ACS is applied.

Expect a scenario, not a quiz: the examiner typically assigns a cross-country ahead of time and asks you to plan it, then questions your weather, performance, airspace and go/no-go reasoning from that plan.

Regulations, charts, weather and planning tools

Use the live government sources rather than a printed FAR/AIM, because the regulations and the AIM both changed during 2026.

Resource	Use it for
eCFR Title 14	Part 1 (definitions), Part 61 (certification: 61.103 to 61.117 for private pilots), Part 91 (operating rules), Part 43 Appendix A (preventive maintenance a pilot may do).
49 CFR Part 830	NTSB accident and incident reporting.
AIM and Pilot/Controller Glossary	Free HTML and PDF, current through Change 3.
FAA charting and data	Free digital sectionals, terminal area charts and the Chart Supplement.
Aeronautical Chart Users' Guide	The legend for every chart symbol.
SkyVector	Free online sectional viewer and flight planner.
Aviation Weather Center	METARs, TAFs, Graphical Forecasts for Aviation, AIRMETs and SIGMETs, winds aloft.
Flight Service (1800wxbrief)	Official weather briefings, NOTAMs and VFR flight plan filing.
Temporary Flight Restrictions	Current TFR list and map.
Airport diagrams	Taxi diagrams and hot spots.
FAASafety.gov	Free online courses and the WINGS program.
FAA "From the Flight Deck"	Videos of runway layouts and hot spots at specific airports.
AOPA Air Safety Institute	Free courses, quizzes and accident case studies.

Learn the paper E6B and plotter as well as an app. Electronic flight calculators are allowed at the test center, but phones and tablets are not.

Test-day and paperwork logistics

You can sit the written at 15 and the result stays valid for 24 calendar months, so it can be passed well before the checkride.

1. Create an IACRA account to get your FAA Tracking Number (FTN). PSI will not let you register without it.
2. Apply for a student pilot certificate in IACRA with your instructor. You need it to solo (age 16); the private certificate itself requires age 17.
3. Book a third-class medical: fill in MedXPress, then see an examiner from the AME locator. Do this early, before spending heavily on flight time.
4. Get the knowledge-test endorsement from your instructor or from a home-study course that issues one.
5. Schedule the PAR test through PSI. The fee is about $175. Bring government photo ID and the endorsement.
6. Keep the score report. If you fail, you need a new instructor endorsement to retest (14 CFR 61.49).
7. Meet the flight experience in 14 CFR 61.109: at least 40 hours total, including 20 with an instructor and 10 solo, with set amounts of cross-country, night and instrument time.
8. Complete the checkride application in IACRA; your instructor signs it as recommending instructor and endorses your logbook; you schedule directly with a Designated Pilot Examiner.

Reuse rights

Only the FAA material can be republished on a study site; the commercial question banks cannot.

Source	Can you republish it?
FAA handbooks, ACS, AIM, testing supplement figures, the PAR sample questions	Yes. U.S. government works are not under copyright in the United States (17 U.S.C. 105). The FAA notes that accuracy of any reproduction is the publisher's responsibility.
Regulations (eCFR)	Yes.

Source	Can you republish it?
Sporty's, King, Gleim, ASA and other commercial banks	No. Their question wording, explanations and software are copyrighted.
Live FAA test questions	Not available. The FAA states that active questions are confidential, so any site claiming "the real questions" is working from recall.

The clean way to build a large original bank is to write new questions against each ACS knowledge code, citing the FAA handbook paragraph that supports the answer. This is general information, not legal advice.

Sources

Pages opened on Oct 3, 2026:

- FAA Airman Certification Standards
- FAA Aviation Handbooks & Manuals
- FAA Airman Testing
- FAA Testing Supplements
- Airman Testing Community Advisory, September 2026 Special Edition
- Airman Testing Community Advisory, August 2026
- FAA PAR sample questions

Found through search results, not opened in full:

- FAA Air Traffic Publications (AIM changes)
- Frequently Missed ACS Codes, July 2024 to June 2025
- Frequently Missed ACS Codes, Oct 2023 to Sept 2024
- Airman Testing Community Advisory, July 2023 (PAR time cut to 120 minutes)
- Sporty's free FAA practice tests
- Sporty's: ASA Private Oral Exam Guide
- Sporty's: ASA Private Pilot Test Prep
- King Schools private pilot course
- Gleim private pilot demos
- Pilot Institute written-test checklist

- Angle of Attack on AC 61-65K
- Pilots of America thread on Sheppard Air and the private written